

Sunset reckoning:

This was the first Wimbledon final since 2002 without Novak Djokovic, Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, or Andy Murray. AFP

DJOKOVIC'S QUEST FOR AN EIGHTH WIMBLEDON TITLE ENDED IN THE SEMIFINAL AGAINST SINNER

7-6(6), 6-4. However, 12 seeds — most notably No. 3 Alexander Zverev, No. 7 and 2024 semifinalist Lorenzo Musetti, No. 8 Holger Rune, and No. 9 Daniil Medvedev — were upset in the first round.

The carnage continued in the second round when 2014 US Open champion Marin Cilic ousted British hopeful and No. 4 Jack Draper, Norrie eliminated No. 12 Frances Tiafoe, and unheralded Austrian Sebastian Ofner stunned No. 13 Tommy Paul. Once again, Fritz survived, but barely. Gabriel Diallo, a wiry 23-year-old Canadian, banged 27 aces before Fritz came through 3-6, 6-3, 7-6(0), 4-6, 6-3.

Cilic's 6-4, 6-3, 1-6, 6-4 victory over Draper, the best British man in the post-Andy Murray era, was the least surprising. As ESPN analyst James

Blake pointed out, referring to the 6'6" Cilic's ability to return Draper's swerving lefty serve, "Cilic has a huge wingspan and one of the best backhands, so this was a great [style] match-up for him."

The heavy home country pressure, an intangible factor that Murray often talked about, clearly did Draper in, particularly on his normally powerful and consistent forehand, which he shanked and timidly sliced during crunch time.

Third-seeded Zverev's 7-6(3), 6-7(8), 6-3, 6-7(5), 6-4 first-round loss to 72nd-ranked Arthur Rinderknech — his earliest elimination at a Major since 2019 — can be partly explained by his off-court anguish. Zverev confided, "It's not a feeling on a tennis court, it's just a life feeling in general. I never felt this way before.

It's difficult to find joy outside the tennis court at the moment. It's something I've felt for the past few months. Again, I just feel generally very, very alone and very lonely."

In Fritz's semifinal against Alcaraz, the Spaniard was a 60 per cent favourite according to *IBM Match Insights*.

A nervous start cost Fritz an opening game service break and the first set. But he battled back in the 88° F heat to end Alcaraz's streak of 42 service holds, when the defending champion played a terrible game, losing his serve at love and the second set, 7-5. Alcaraz regained his groove to take the third set, 6-3, and surged to a 4-1 lead in the fourth set tie-break. Stuningly, Fritz took the next five points to get two set points at 6-4. Alcaraz reversed the momentum one last time, grabbing the last four points — the most exciting one coming on a forehand passing shot for 5-6 — to win the tie-break and the match 6-4, 5-7, 6-3, 7-6(8).